



Office of Public Affairs
U.S. Department of Justice



Florida Nonprofit Founder and Accountant Charged with Stealing Over \$100M from Special Needs Victims

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For Immediate Release

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An indictment was unsealed today charging two Florida men in connection with a fraudulent scheme to steal over \$100 million from a nonprofit organization that managed funds for people with special needs and disabilities.

"As alleged, for over 15 years, the defendants conspired to use the funds of special needs clients as a personal piggy bank, stealing \$100 million dollars meant for the most vulnerable members of our society to enrich themselves," said Matthew R. Galeotti, Head of the Justice Department's Criminal Division.

"Today's charges reflect the Criminal Division's ongoing commitment to prosecuting sophisticated fraudsters who abuse the trust of their victims. Thanks to the relentless efforts of our multiagency partners, we will continue to aggressively pursue accountability for perpetrators who exploit Americans out of greed."

"Protecting the most vulnerable members of our society is a priority of the U. S. Attorney's Office," said U.S. Attorney Gregory W. Kehoe for the Middle District of Florida. "The fraud alleged in this nationwide scheme is unfathomable. Due to the diligence and interagency collaboration by our dedicated law enforcement partners, these crimes will be prosecuted to the fullest extent of the law."

"The subjects charged are accused of creating a slush fund to divert millions of dollars away from a nonprofit organization helping people with special needs," said Assistant Director Jose A. Perez of the FBI Criminal Investigative Division. "Not only were the organization's resources drained, but the accused subjects betrayed the trust of the community and ultimately bankrupted a lifeline for vulnerable families. The FBI will not tolerate the exploitation of charitable missions for personal enrichment."

"The scale and audacity of the alleged fraud in this case are deeply troubling," said Criminal Investigation Chief Guy Ficco of the IRS. "Stealing funds intended to protect and support people with

special needs is as cruel as it is criminal. IRS-CI special agents are dedicated to uncovering complex financial schemes, especially those that prey on the most vulnerable in our society."

"The defendant disrupted access to critical services for individuals with disabilities and defrauded federal health care programs with the sole purpose of financing a life of extravagance," said Deputy Inspector General for Investigations Christian J. Schrank of the U. S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General (HHS-OIG). "HHS-OIG, in collaboration with our law enforcement partners, will continue to hold those whose illicit actions seek to assail enrollees and the nation's federal health care programs fully accountable."

According to court documents, Leo Joseph Govoni, 67, of Clearwater, Florida, co-founded the Center for Special Needs Trust Administration (CSNT) in or around 2000 and John Leo Witeck, 60, of Tampa, Florida, worked at CSNT as an accountant. CSNT allegedly was a nonprofit that managed money for people with disabilities and other special needs, including those who received court awards, settlements, and other payments. CSNT grew to be one of the largest administrators of special needs trusts in the country, with beneficiaries located in almost every state. As of February 2024, the indictment alleges, CSNT managed over 2,100 special needs trusts containing approximately \$200 million.

As alleged in the indictment, from June 2009 through May 2025, Govoni, Witeck, and their co-conspirators solicited, stole, and misappropriated CSNT client-beneficiary funds — which they treated as a slush fund to enrich themselves and others — and concealed their illegal activities through complex financial transactions and deceit, including sending fraudulent account statements with false balances to disabled victims. Govoni allegedly used stolen money to purchase real estate, travel via private jet, fund a brewery, make deposits into his personal bank accounts, and pay personal debts. In 2024, CSNT filed for bankruptcy and disclosed that more than \$100 million in client-beneficiary funds were missing from its trust accounts. Govoni is alleged to have made false declarations to the bankruptcy court related to the CSNT bankruptcy proceedings.

Separately, Govoni is also alleged to have committed bank fraud related to a \$3 million mortgage refinance loan and to have laundered \$205,054 of the proceeds to pay off a home equity line of credit on his residence.

Govoni and Witeck were both charged with conspiracy to commit wire and mail fraud, wire fraud, mail fraud, and money laundering conspiracy. Govoni was additionally charged with bank fraud, illegal monetary transactions, and false bankruptcy declarations.

If convicted, both defendants face a maximum penalty of 20 years in prison on the wire fraud, mail fraud, conspiracy to commit wire and mail fraud, and money laundering conspiracy charges. If convicted, Govoni faces a maximum penalty of 30 years in prison on the bank fraud charge, 10 years in prison on the illegal monetary transactions charge, and five years in prison on the false bankruptcy declaration charge.

The FBI, IRS-CI, HHS-OIG, and SSA-OIG are investigating the case.

Trial Attorney Lyndie Freeman of the Criminal Division’s Fraud Section and Assistant U. S. Attorneys Jennifer Peresie and Michael Gordon for the Middle District of Florida are handling the prosecution.

An indictment is merely an allegation. All defendants are presumed innocent until proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt in a court of law.

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